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CMPM 180: Moving Texts

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Artistic Statement – Project 3: Installation

For Project 3, in light of using the code as the artistic medium, I created this project “The Feeling Mixer” that grew out of me after being tired of my own aesthetic. Basically my last two projects were somewhat dark and subtle, or say quite, and about things disappearing like the texts fading away over time or the room that refuses to remember you once you stop paying attention. Everything was about loss. So this time, I pushed myself the other way. Something more constructive, something with sliders and buttons that would act like a tool.

The primary idea is mixing console for the basic emotions that humans are surrounded by. Six sliders – hope, dread (because, I thought “dread” sounds much cooler than “sadness”), nostalgia, calm, longing, and joy. As you drag them, a landscape rearranges itself to match. The sun rises or sinks, the sky changes, fog rolls in with elevated dread, stars appear when it’s calm and dark. Also, there’s a far-off light that only shows up when longing is high. Underneath the landscape, I have captions that attempts to put the generated landscape into words. Captions are handpicked from the readings and modified to match the landscape. Additionally, there are some presets named after moments, which honestly was my favorite part to write, since each one is basically a tiny story compressed into six sliders.

However, the reason it kept nagging at me is the question I couldn’t shake – how do you actually know what you feel? And Can it be parametrized? Feelings aren’t like switches, on/off mechanism. Afterall, they are blends. One can feel nostalgic and hopeful at once, calm and longing together. So I wanted to externalize that, get it outside myself so I could look at it.

This is where Ong struck me. He talks about how writing separates the known from the knower, how it turns something that lives inside you into an object you can stand back and observe. And then I thought, isn’t this

what the project is doing. It is actually taking a mushy mood and turning it into sliders and a picture you can stare at and adjust. So you are the one who is feeling it, while watching it. Honestly, sliding own dread up and down like a volume knob is little unsettling, but also tender, like you are finally giving the feeling room to exist.

Just like Committa's nature book where he claims that there's no actual nature in his book, and it's all projection, my landscape is same. It is not a place, it is what I project onto color and light based on a feeling, *Entirely Human*. It is about naming things, about how naming a feeling, even just sliding the bar up is a way of knowing it. I mean you can't tune what you won't look at. It is not deep, but a toy. A toy about the weather inside you, and I think that's enough.

Link to Repo: <https://github.com/LegionDotEXE/Feeling-Mixer>

Link to Page: <https://legiondotexe.github.io/Feeling-Mixer/>